INTERVIEWING

Facilitator's Guide

DESCRIPTION	Utilize this facilitator's guide for: • Interviewing Video • Questions to Ask Candidate Resource Sheet • Building an Effective Team Starts with the Interview Resource Sheet
OBJECTIVES	Participants should be able to: • Understand best practices of interviewing • Apply the STAR model of question development to inform the interview process • Identify which best practice questions are most beneficial in the interview process • Understand the importance of building relationships during the interview process • Identify unconscious bias in the interview process
Time for Facilitation	Between 20 - 60 minutes

Introduction

Brief Starting Intro:

Training leaders in the art of interviewing candidates is a crucial investment for any organization striving to foster a culture of excellence and innovation. The interview process is not merely about evaluating a candidate's skills and qualifications but also about identifying individuals who resonate with the company's values and vision. Leaders equipped with advanced interviewing techniques can better discern the subtle cues that indicate a candidate's potential for long-term success within the organization. By honing these skills, leaders can make more informed decisions, thereby reducing the costly turnover rates and enhancing team cohesion and productivity.

Moreover, the manner in which interviews are conducted reflects the organization's brand and values, significantly impacting its attractiveness to top talent. Leaders who are adept at

interviewing not only elevate the candidate's experience but also bolster the organization's reputation in the competitive job market. Through effective training, leaders can learn to craft interviews that are both rigorous and engaging, ensuring that candidates, regardless of the outcome, become ambassadors of the company's brand. This strategic approach to interviews, rooted in a deep understanding of the organization's goals and the nuances of human interaction, ultimately contributes to building a robust and dynamic workforce that is capable of navigating the complexities of today's business landscape.

Pre-Facilitation: Check with participants to see if they watched the video and read the resource articles. They should have both watched and read the resources prior to asking the following questions.

Best Practice Facilitation: Place participants into pairs of two so that they can share first with the other participant before sharing their answer with the whole group. This “pair and share” technique allows individuals to test out their answer(s) with someone else first (instilling confidence in the answer) and helps to start building stronger relationships with others in the program.

Depending on the time you have, select the questions that work within your schedule for training. Since we are utilizing the “pair and share” method, you should provide the participants with 2 minutes each to discuss their answers (let them know when to switch to keep them on time). Then have those who want to share their answers with the whole group a chance to do so (select 2 or 3 people to share - do not force participation). This can take up to 5 minutes. In total the pair and share technique for each question will take approximately 10 minutes. If you do not use the pair and share, allow 5-7 minutes for individuals to respond to the whole group.

Interviewing Video General

The following questions are based on the video:

1. Think back on your experience(s) being interviewed for different positions over your career. Without using names or the company, how was the experience? What do you remember about the experience that was positive? What do you remember about the experience that you would consider negative? Do you utilize any of these experiences to shape the way you interview? If yes, which experiences and how have they shaped your interviewing practices?
2. Select a common competency or skill that you often evaluate in those interviewing for a position within the organization (e.g., teamwork, leadership, problem-solving, conflict resolution, creativity):
   a. Create a question you could use in an interview, using the STAR model, to assess the competency or skill you selected above.
      i. **(S)ituation**: Start the question with a prompt that gets the candidate to set the scene. [Example: Can you describe a specific situation where you encountered a

significant problem that threatened to delay or derail a project you were working on?]

ii. **(T)ask**: Develop the question that asks the candidate to describe the challenge or responsibility they faced. [Example: What was the immediate task or responsibility you had in addressing that problem?]

iii. **(A)ction**: Formulate the question to encourage the candidate to explain the actions they took. [Example: What specific actions did you take to solve the problem? Were there any innovative or unconventional methods you employed?]

iv. **(R)esults**: Finally, design the question that requires the candidate to outline the outcomes of their actions. [Example: What was the outcome of your actions? How did the solution impact the project or the team?]

b. What insights do you hope to gain from the candidate's response to this question on this competency? Have you constructed it in a way that achieves these insights?

3. What is one best practice that you learned from the video (or the conversation you had with others) that you can put into practice the next time you interview? What likely impact would utilizing this practice have on the interview?

Additional Activity on Interviewing:

1. **Self-Assessment**: Begin the workshop by providing participants with the Leadership Interview Skills self-assessment questionnaire provided. Encourage them to reflect on their current interviewing habits, strengths, and areas for improvement. Ask participants to rate their effectiveness in key areas such as preparation and understanding of the role, communication and listening skills, ability to create a comfortable and unbiased interview environment, and use of varied interview techniques.
2. **Group Discussion**: Facilitate a group discussion where participants share their self-assessment results and insights. Encourage open dialogue about common challenges and best practices in conducting interviews. Guide participants to identify common themes and patterns in their interviewing habits.

Questions to Ask Candidates Resource

The following questions are based on the Questions to Ask Candidates Article:

1. After reviewing the "Questions to Ask" resource, which of the 12 questions were most valuable for you to ask in an interview to find the best fit candidate to work on your team? What insight do you gain from these questions?
2. Utilizing the STAR model, you learned about in the video, what would you add to these questions to get the information you would need to make a good hiring decision?
3. What is the likelihood that you would use this resource in the hiring process? Depending on your answer, why or why would you not utilize this resource?
4. Over your career of hiring or being hired, what is a 13th question you would add to this list? What insight would it provide you by asking this question? What would your rubric look like to distinguish between candidates who answered the question excellent, good, fair, or poor?

5. How could you encourage others, that you lead, to ask question during the hiring process that are similar to those in the "Questions to Ask Candidates" resource sheet? How important is it for you team to be utilizing the STAR model when they are part of the interview process?

Additional Questions to Ask Candidates Activity:

1. **Taking a Test Drive:**
   a. **Group Division (5 minutes):** Divide participants into small groups of 2 people to encourage more intimate discussion and sharing.
   b. **Select Interviewer and Candidate (5 minutes):** Have the pair decide who is the interviewer and the candidate.
   c. **Practice Two Questions (5 minutes):** Engage in the interview process:
      i. Set Up (Situation): The situation is that the candidate (as determined from step 2) is interviewing for the job they have right now. If the individual is the V.P. of Marketing, then they are answering the questions based on being the candidate for the V.P. of Marketing job.
      ii. Interviewer: The interviewer is to select 2 questions from the 12 questions on the resource sheet and ask them to the candidate (the other person in the group of two)
      iii. Candidate: The candidate is to answer the questions, to the best of their ability, taking into account they are interviewing for the job they are in at this point.
   d. **Discussion Questions**:
      i. For those who were the Interviewer: How were the questions received? What information/insight did you learn about the candidate for the job? What changes would you make to the questions (if any) to gain more insight into the candidate for the position?
      ii. For those who were the candidate: What did you learn from answering the 2 questions as a candidate or as a interviewer? Was it difficult or easy answering the questions (especially since you have the job)? What insight did you learn about the question or what candidates go through in answering the question by engaging in this role play?
   e. **Switch roles and select two different questions.**

Building an Effective Team Starts with the Interview

The following questions are based on the Building an Effective Team Starts with the Interview Article:

1. After reading the "Building an Effective Team Starts with the Interview" resource, what type of first impression do you think you present to candidates? Which of the best practices discussed in the article do you engage in when interviewing? Which of the best practices should you consider engaging in as you move forward with your interviewing practices?

2. When you have an interview to conduct, what is your thoughts and feelings about that experience? Reflecting on this answer, how do you think it impacts the way that you interview? How does it impact the candidate's experience? How might this impact the way your team engages in the interviewing process?
3. When you think about your leadership, your team, and the organization, what are the vales that a candidate needs to have to be successful? Currently, how are you ensuring that these values are present in the candidates you hire/recommend? Ask your team, what values are critical to the success of a new employee when it comes to working on the team or in the organization. How similar were these values to the ones you identified?
4. What steps are you taking to keep your unconscious bias in check and provide space for all candidates to be treated fairly? Do you have any unconscious bias that you have been able to reflect on that may have impacted your hiring practices in the past? In your opinion, how diverse (in the broadest sense of the team) is your team or the organization? Why do you think it is or is not diverse?
5. What do you think would be the impact if you sent out a "Thank you for interviewing with us" email after the interview? In your opinion, is this a positive or negative idea? Why? If it is a positive idea, how can you structure this process to assure that it gets done after the interview?

Additional Building an Effective Team Starts with the Interview Activity:

1. **Case Study**: Hand out the 5 unconscious bias case studies below. Have each group read the case study and answer the questions. Bring the group back together and conduct a general discussion around the answers and unconscious bias.

Leadership Interview Skills Self-Assessment

Instructions: Please rate each statement on a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 indicates "Strongly Disagree" and 5 indicates "Strongly Agree."

1. I clearly understand the role and competencies required for the position I am interviewing for.

1 2 3 4 5

2. I prepare specific questions in advance that relate directly to the role's requirements.

1 2 3 4 5

3. I create a welcoming interview environment that puts candidates at ease.

1 2 3 4 5

4. I actively listen to the candidate's responses without interrupting.

1 2 3 4 5

5. I am able to read non-verbal cues and adjust my approach accordingly during the interview.

1 2 3 4 5

6. I encourage candidates to ask questions and address their concerns effectively.

1 2 3 4 5

7. I ensure that my questions are open-ended to elicit comprehensive responses.

1 2 3 4 5

8. I avoid biases and make objective decisions based on the candidate's qualifications and potential.

1 2 3 4 5

9. I provide clear, constructive feedback to all candidates, regardless of the outcome.

1 2 3 4 5

10. I am consistent in my interviewing approach with all candidates to ensure fairness.

1 2 3 4 5

11. I effectively communicate the company's values and culture to the candidate.

1 2 3 4 5

12. I follow up with candidates in a timely manner after the interview.

1 2 3 4 5

13. I reflect on my interviewing techniques regularly and seek feedback to improve.

1 2 3 4 5

14. I maintain confidentiality and respect the privacy of all candidates.

1 2 3 4 5

15. I use a variety of interview formats (e.g., behavioral, situational) as appropriate.

1 2 3 4 5

16. I collaborate with my team to evaluate candidates comprehensively.

1 2 3 4 5

17. I am aware of and comply with legal and ethical standards in interviewing.

1 2 3 4 5

18. I strive to make the interview process informative and engaging for the candidate.

1 2 3 4 5

19. I manage my time effectively during the interview to cover all necessary aspects.

1 2 3 4 5

20. I keep detailed notes during the interview for accurate assessment and follow-up.

1 2 3 4 5

Scoring: Calculate your total score by adding up the ratings for each statement. A higher score indicates stronger feedback skills and habits.

Total Score: _____

Interpretation:

- **80-100**: **Exceptional Interviewer** - You possess outstanding interviewing skills that likely contribute significantly to your organization's success in talent acquisition. Continue refining your approach and sharing your expertise with others.
- **60-79**: **Competent Interviewer** - You have a strong foundation in interviewing candidates, but there's room for improvement. Focus on areas where you scored lower to enhance your effectiveness.
- **40-59**: **Developing Interviewer** - You are on your way to becoming a skilled interviewer but need to address several areas for improvement. Consider seeking mentorship or training to develop your interviewing skills further.
- **20-39**: **Novice Interviewer** - You may be new to interviewing or struggle with some aspects of the process. It's essential to seek out resources, training, and feedback to improve your skills.
- **Below 20**: **Developing Interviewer** - **Beginner Interviewer** - Interviewing is a complex skill set that requires practice and learning. It's advisable to thoroughly familiarize yourself with interviewing techniques and consider formal training.

Case Study: The Bias in Tech Talent Acquisition

Background:

TechGlobal, a leading software development company, prides itself on innovation and diversity. The company is in the process of hiring a senior software engineer to lead a new project aimed at developing cutting-edge AI solutions. The hiring panel consists of the project manager, Sarah, a seasoned developer, Mike, and the HR manager, Alex. They have shortlisted two candidates, Jordan and Casey, for the final interview based on their impressive resumes and initial screening calls.

The Interview Process:

During the final interviews, both candidates are asked to solve a technical problem and discuss their previous project experiences.

- **Jordan** presents a solid technical solution but struggles slightly with articulating the process. Jordan mentions working on similar AI projects, highlighting collaboration with diverse teams across different time zones.
- **Casey** provides a similar technical solution with more confidence and clarity in explanation. Casey focuses on individual contributions to past projects, emphasizing personal achievements and technical expertise without much mention of teamwork or diversity.

After the interviews, the panel discusses the candidates.

- **Sarah** is impressed with Casey's clear communication and technical confidence, noting these as critical for the project's success. She expresses concerns about Jordan's articulation, questioning their ability to lead.
- **Mike** values Jordan's experience with diverse teams and believes their technical skills are on par with Casey's. He argues that Jordan's slightly less polished communication could be due to nerves and doesn't detract from their overall fit for the role.
- **Alex** remains neutral but points out that the hiring decision seems to be leaning towards Casey, prompting a discussion on whether the panel's preferences are influenced by biases.

Reflection Points:

Communication Style Bias: Sarah's preference for Casey's articulate presentation over Jordan's technical solution and diverse team experience might indicate a bias towards candidates who communicate in a style similar to her own, potentially overlooking the value of diversity and collaboration skills.

Confirmation Bias: The panel entered the interviews with a preconceived idea of the ideal candidate, possibly leading them to interpret candidates' responses in a way that confirms their

initial impressions.

Individual Achievement vs. Team Collaboration: The panel's differing views on the importance of individual technical prowess versus collaborative experience highlight a potential bias towards solo achievements over teamwork in tech roles.

Discussion Questions:

- How might the panel's biases, if any, be influencing their evaluation of the candidates?
- What steps could the panel take to mitigate these biases and make a more balanced hiring decision?
- How can TechGlobal ensure a more inclusive interview process that values diverse skills and experiences?
- This case study prompts leaders to recognize and address biases in their decision-making processes, encouraging a more inclusive and equitable approach to hiring.

Case Study: Marketing Maven or Industry Insider?

Background:

QuickShift, an emerging logistics company, is looking to hire a new Marketing Director to spearhead their expansion into new markets. The hiring committee is composed of Elena, the CEO, Tom, the current Marketing Director who is transitioning to a consultant role, and Priya, the Head of HR. After several rounds of interviews, the choice has narrowed down to two candidates: Avery and Taylor.

- **Avery** has a decade of marketing experience within the logistics industry, including direct competitors. Avery's strategies have significantly increased market share for their previous employers, but during the interview, Avery seems to rely heavily on industry-specific tactics and jargon.
- **Taylor** comes from a tech background, with a strong track record of innovative marketing campaigns that have garnered attention across industries. Taylor lacks direct logistics industry experience but shows a clear ability to adapt and learn quickly, offering fresh perspectives during the interview.

The Interview Feedback:

During the deliberation, each committee member expresses their preferences:

- **Elena** appreciates Taylor's innovative approach and sees potential for disruption in the logistics marketing space, emphasizing the need for out-of-the-box thinking to stand out.
- **Tom** leans towards Avery, citing the steep learning curve in understanding the logistics market's nuances and the value of industry connections that Avery brings.
- **Priya** notes a potential bias in the committee's discussion, observing that the debate may reflect pre-existing preferences for "like-minded" versus "industry-experienced" candidates.

Reflection Points:

Industry Bias: Tom's preference for Avery might indicate a bias toward candidates with industry-specific experience, potentially undervaluing the innovation and fresh perspectives an outsider like Taylor could bring.

Innovation Bias: Elena's leaning towards Taylor suggests a possible bias towards innovative and disruptive thinking, potentially overlooking the immediate benefits of Avery's industry experience and established networks.

Confirmation Bias: The committee members seem to favor candidates who reflect their personal biases towards what the role should prioritize (industry knowledge vs. innovative approach), which

could lead to overlooking the balanced strengths each candidate brings.

Discussion Questions:

- How can the committee ensure a fair evaluation of both candidates' potential contributions to QuickShift's growth?
- What steps could be taken to minimize the impact of personal biases in future hiring decisions?
- Considering QuickShift's immediate and long-term goals, how should the importance of industry experience versus innovative thinking be weighed in this decision?

Case Study: The Engineering Conundrum

Background:

InnovateX, a leading firm in the renewable energy sector, is in the process of hiring a Senior Electrical Engineer to lead their next-generation solar panel project. The interview panel consists of Liam, the Engineering Manager, Zoe, the Lead Project Designer, and Raj, the Diversity and Inclusion Officer. After several rounds of interviews, the decision has narrowed down to two candidates: Sam and Alex.

- **Sam** has over 15 years of experience in electrical engineering, with a significant portion of that time spent specifically in solar energy. Sam's interview responses were technically detailed, showing deep expertise but sometimes lacked clarity in communicating complex ideas to non-expert audiences.
- **Alex**, with a decade of experience, has a more diverse background, including wind and solar energy projects. Alex demonstrated exceptional communication skills during the interview, clearly explaining technical concepts and how they would approach project challenges, albeit with slightly less direct experience in solar energy compared to Sam.

The Interview Feedback:

During the deliberation, the panelists express their views:

- **Liam** is inclined toward Sam, valuing the depth of specific technical expertise in solar energy, which he believes is crucial for the project's ambitious goals. He expresses concerns about whether Alex's broader experience can translate into the specialized focus the project requires.
- **Zoe** prefers Alex, highlighting the importance of clear communication in collaborative project work and Alex's ability to engage with the broader team and stakeholders effectively. She argues that Alex's diverse experience could bring fresh perspectives to the project.
- **Raj** points out potential biases in the discussion, noting that the preference might be influenced by traditional views on what constitutes "expertise" and "leadership" in engineering roles.

Reflection Points:

Expertise Bias: Liam's preference for Sam may reflect a bias toward traditional markers of expertise, potentially underestimating the value of interdisciplinary knowledge and communication skills that Alex brings.

Communication vs. Technical Skills: The debate highlights a common conundrum in hiring for technical positions: the weighing of deep technical skills against the ability to communicate and collaborate effectively across disciplines.

Bias Awareness: Raj's observations prompt a reflection on how unconscious biases related to professional backgrounds, experience, and even communication style can influence hiring decisions.

Discussion Questions:

- How can the panel balance the need for specialized expertise with the project's collaborative and interdisciplinary nature?
- In what ways can the panel address and mitigate potential biases in evaluating candidates' qualifications and fit for the role?
- Considering InnovateX's innovation-driven culture, how should the panel evaluate the potential for fresh perspectives against the security of proven experience?

Case Study: The Leadership Leap

Background:

FinTech Innovations, a rapidly growing startup in the financial technology sector, is seeking a new Vice President of Product Development to drive the next phase of product innovation and market expansion. The selection committee is comprised of Maya, the CEO; Darren, the current VP of Engineering; and Tasha, the Chief Operations Officer. After a rigorous recruitment process, the final decision rests between two candidates: Robin and Jamie.

- **Robin** comes from a well-established competitor, with a proven track record of leading large teams and launching successful products. Robin impressed the panel with their strategic vision and detailed knowledge of the fintech market. However, Robin appeared more reserved, emphasizing process and risk management over rapid innovation in their responses.
- **Jamie** has a background in a series of successful tech startups, demonstrating a knack for agile development and a strong entrepreneurial spirit. Jamie's approach to the interview was energetic, focusing on fast-paced innovation and a willingness to disrupt established markets. Jamie's experience with team leadership, however, has been on a smaller scale compared to Robin's.

The Interview Feedback:

- **Maya** sees Jamie as the embodiment of the startup spirit, appreciating their drive for innovation and risk-taking as essential for breaking new ground in the fintech space.
- **Darren** favors Robin, arguing that their experience in leading larger teams and understanding the complexities of the fintech industry are critical for the company's next growth phase.
- **Tasha** points out that the committee's preferences might be influenced by their own biases towards either preserving the status quo or pushing for rapid innovation, without fully considering the balance needed between these approaches.

Reflection Points:

Innovation Bias vs. Stability Bias: Maya's preference for Jamie might stem from an innovation bias, valuing disruptive potential over the stability that Robin offers, while Darren's support for Robin may indicate a bias towards proven experience and risk aversion.

Scale of Experience: The committee is grappling with the question of what is more valuable for the role: Robin's experience in managing large-scale projects and teams or Jamie's agile, entrepreneurial approach to product development.

Bias in Leadership Style: Tasha's observations suggest that implicit biases about leadership styles (e.g., favoring bold innovators over cautious strategists) may be influencing the decision-making

process.

Discussion Questions:

- How can the committee ensure a balanced evaluation of both candidates, considering the startup's need for both innovation and stability?
- What steps can be taken to identify and mitigate any unconscious biases that may be affecting the committee's decision?
- How should the company weigh the importance of experience at scale versus the ability to innovate and adapt in a rapidly evolving industry?

Case Study: Shifting Gears in AutoTech

Background:

AutoTech Dynamics, a leading player in the automotive technology industry, is in the hunt for a new Chief Financial Officer (CFO) to navigate the company through an ambitious phase of growth and diversification. The hiring panel includes Clara, the CEO; Evan, the Senior Vice President of Operations; and Leslie, the Director of Human Resources. The final round of interviews has narrowed down to two candidates: Jordan and Pat.

- **Jordan** has over two decades of experience in the financial departments of major automotive companies, boasting a track record of managing finances through periods of significant industry shifts. Jordan's interview responses were highly analytical, focusing on long-term financial strategies and risk management. However, Jordan seemed less familiar with the latest financial technology tools.
- **Pat** comes from a fintech background, with experience in leveraging cutting-edge financial technologies to optimize budgeting, forecasting, and investment strategies. Pat's responses were innovative and forward-thinking, showing less experience in traditional automotive sectors but a keen insight into financial technology trends. Pat exhibited a dynamic approach to financial management, emphasizing agility and technological integration.

The Interview Feedback:

- **Clara** is intrigued by Pat's innovative approach, seeing it as a potential catalyst for modernizing AutoTech Dynamics' financial operations and embracing digital transformation in the automotive sector.
- **Evan** expresses a preference for Jordan, valuing their deep industry knowledge and experience in navigating the financial challenges specific to the automotive world. Evan is concerned that Pat's lack of industry-specific experience might be a significant hurdle.
- **Leslie** raises concerns about potential biases in the panel's decision-making, noting a divide between favoring industry experience over innovative, tech-savvy approaches. Leslie suggests that this dichotomy might reflect broader biases towards traditional versus modern approaches in the company's leadership.

Reflection Points:

Industry Experience vs. Technological Innovation: The panel is confronted with a classic dilemma: the value of deep industry experience (Jordan) versus the potential for innovation and modernization brought by a newcomer (Pat).

Bias Towards Tradition vs. Change: Evan's and Clara's preferences might reveal underlying biases in the company's strategic direction—whether to prioritize stability and traditional

knowledge or to push the boundaries with new technologies and approaches.

Adaptability and Learning: The discussion around Jordan's lack of familiarity with the latest fintech tools versus Pat's agility and readiness to leverage technology highlights the importance of adaptability and continuous learning in leadership roles.

Discussion Questions:

- How can the hiring panel objectively evaluate the importance of industry experience against the need for innovation and technological adaptability in the CFO role?
- What strategies can AutoTech Dynamics employ to ensure that biases towards traditional or modern approaches do not unduly influence hiring decisions?
- Considering the company's ambitions for growth and diversification, how should the balance between financial stability and technological innovation influence the final decision?